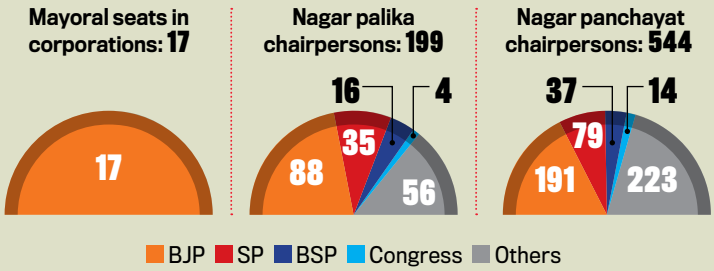
A BURST OF SAFFRON

The urban body polls were a washout for the Opposition, but it will be the BJP's gains in UP's rural areas that will be a bigger worry



ago. And at a rally on May 2 in Prayagraj, where Atiq once ran his fief, Yogi let the metaphors rip: "The world runs by the law of *karma...ye prakriti sabka hisaab baraabar kar deti hai* (everyone's accounts are settled on earth)."

Justice activists and the Opposition criticise the Yogi Adityanath government for extrajudicial killings, but the tough-on-crime 'Baba bulldozer' image has fetched the BJP electoral returns. The party even scored a "historic first" in Muslim-dominated Deoband, where Vipin Kumar, a former functionary of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, has been elected nagar palika parishad chairman. After the results, Yogi said the public has given a mandate for "good governance, development and fear-free environment".

As for the SP, it really needs to step back and introspect on why a 36 per cent vote share (in alliance) in the 2022 assembly poll has not translated into even a single win in the urban mayoral seats a year later. The cracks in the alliance were showing as the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) fielded its own candidates in several nagar palika and nagar panchayat seats where SP candidates were also contesting. There were a lot of complaints from local SP leaders too on the way tickets were distributed. The party's core Muslim vote bank also did not consolidate for these polls (in fact, 61 of the 391 Muslim candidates the BJP fielded won; five of them are now nagar panchayat chairpersons).

The BSP and Congress also got significant Muslim votes in pockets. In Moradabad, Jhansi and Shahjahanpur, the Congress was the runner-up in the mayoral seats whereas the BSP came second in Agra, Ghaziabad and Saharanpur mayoral seats. The AIMIM (All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) candidate came in second in Meerut.

UP-based political analyst Dr Shilp Shikha Singh says, "The big win in the urban body polls was not surprising as the BJP has a proven track record there, but the improvement in tally in nagar palika and nagar panchayat seats is a significant change. And the fact that Muslim votes did not coalesce around the SP should worry that party." ■

The SP has to introspect on why it has lost ground a year after the good show in the assembly polls

By Kaushik Deka

Who should control the transfer and postings of bureaucrats in the national capital territory (NCT)? Here was a verdict that said Arvind Kejriwal's government, and not the Centre's representative, the lieutenant-governor (L-G), would have the final say over 'services' in Delhi. On May 11, what the five-judge constitution bench headed by Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud delivered was a unanimous verdict in favour of the Delhi regime. By all logic, that should have brought closure to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) regime's eight-year-old dispute with the BJP-led Union government.

However, less than 24 hours after the ruling, the battle saw another chapter opening. The AAP regime issued an order transferring services secretary Ashish More. But not only did More's department not act on the order, it also called the move "illegal", saying the court had earlier directed the central/state governments to establish a Civil Services Board to examine transfers before an officer's term was completed. AAP leaders, including services minister Saurabh Bhardwaj, allege More then went incommunicado, switching off his mobile phone. The Delhi government knocked on the doors of the apex court again, claiming interference and possible contempt of court by the Centre as More's actions allegedly violate the May 11 ruling. Justice Chandrachud has said he would constitute a bench to hear the matter.

The turf war over the appointments and transfers of bureaucrats—whose domain falls under 'services', under Entry 41 of the State List of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution—started in 2015, just months after AAP came to power in Delhi. The state list categorises the areas over which state governments and assemblies have exclusive executive/legislative authority. The Union government has exclusive authority over subjects in the